

Case Study : *"I Am Still With You"* by Emmanuel Iduma

Important Note on Genre: While often read with the narrative drive of a novel, this book is actually a **memoir** (non-fiction). It blends travelogue, history, and personal essay. It is a real-life investigation into the author's family history and the scars of the Nigerian Civil War.

I. Context and Premise

The Subject: The book focuses on the **Nigerian Civil War (the Biafran War)**, which took place from 1967 to 1970. This conflict, which resulted in the deaths of over a million people (mostly Igbos) due to fighting and starvation, remains a sensitive and often silenced topic in Nigerian public discourse.

The Catalyst: Emmanuel Iduma, who had been living in New York, returns to Nigeria to attend his father's funeral. This return triggers a quest to uncover the truth about his uncle, **Golibe**, who disappeared during the war. Golibe was his father's beloved brother, and his absence was a "shadow" that hung over the family for decades.

II. Detailed Summary of the Narrative Arc

The narrative is structured around Iduma's physical journey across eastern Nigeria (formerly Biafra) and his psychological journey into the past.

1. The Return and the Question

Iduma arrives in Nigeria with a singular obsession: to find out what happened to Golibe. The official family narrative is vague—he went to war and never came back. There is no body, no grave, and no official record of death. This lack of closure is a source of "ambiguous loss" for the family.

2. The Investigation (The Road Trip)

Iduma travels through cities central to the Biafran resistance: **Enugu**, **Umuahia**, and **Owerri**. He acts as a detective of memory.

- **The Search for Witnesses:** He tracks down elderly survivors, distant relatives, and friends who might have known Golibe.
- **The Fragmented Truth:** He learns that Golibe enlisted in the Biafran army. However, accounts of his fate differ. Was he killed in an ambush? Was he executed by his own side? Did he starve? The truth is elusive.
- **The Broader Picture:** As he searches for one man, Iduma encounters the stories of many. He speaks to people who carry the physical and mental scars of the war—former child soldiers, women who lost children to hunger, and men who still feel the humiliation of defeat.

3. The Encounter with Silence

A major part of the summary is the **resistance** Iduma faces.

- **His Father:** Before his death, Iduma's father was reluctant to speak about Golibe. The pain was too great.
- **The Nation:** Iduma finds that Nigeria as a country has chosen "collective amnesia" regarding the war. There are few official memorials. The motto "No Victor, No Vanquished" (declared after the war) effectively silenced the victims' need to mourn.

4. The Discovery

Iduma eventually pieces together a likely scenario: Golibe did not die a "heroic" death in combat but was likely a victim of the chaotic infighting or the brutal conditions within the Biafran ranks themselves. However, the book does not end with a forensic "case closed" conclusion. Instead, it ends with the realization that **the search itself is the memorial**. By looking for Golibe, Iduma has brought him back to life in the only way possible—through memory.

III. Key Figures (Characters)

Since this is a memoir, these are real people, but they function as character archetypes within the narrative.

1. Emmanuel Iduma (The Seeker)

The narrator. He represents the **post-war generation** (or the "third generation"). He did not experience the war, but he inherits its trauma. He is also the **Diaspora Returnee**—he looks at Nigeria with both the intimacy of a native and the critical distance of an outsider living in America.

2. Golibe (The Ghost)

The missing uncle. He is the **Absent Protagonist**. We never meet him, but the entire book revolves around him. He represents the millions of "unknown soldiers" and missing civilians of the Biafran War. His name, *Golibe*, means "Rejoice," adding a tragic irony to his fate.

3. The Father

Iduma's father is a figure of **Stoic Grief**. He represents the generation that survived the war by burying their pain. His silence is not out of malice, but out of a survival instinct. Iduma's quest is, in part, an attempt to have the conversation with his father that he couldn't have while his father was alive.

IV. Key Themes

1. The Inheritance of Trauma

The book explores how trauma is passed down from parents to children. Even though Iduma didn't fight in the war, he feels its weight. The silence of the older generation creates a "haunting" for the younger generation.

2. Memory vs. Amnesia

This is the central conflict.

- **State Amnesia:** The Nigerian government wishes to move on and forget the tribal divisions of the war.
- **Personal Memory:** The families of the missing cannot move on. Iduma argues that without remembering and acknowledging the dead, the nation cannot truly heal.

3. The "Black Box" of War

Iduma frequently uses the metaphor of the "black box." War is a chaotic event where people enter and simply vanish. The logic of cause-and-effect breaks down. He writes against the idea of a sanitized history, showing the messy, unresolved reality of conflict.

4. The Power of the Image

As an art critic, Iduma is obsessed with photographs. He discusses how few photos exist of the war and of his uncle. He explores how photographs preserve memory, but also how the *lack* of a photograph (an empty space in an album) can be just as powerful.

V. Symbols

- **The Photograph:** Photos are symbols of **proof of existence**. Iduma cherishes the few blurred images he has of Golibe. The book itself includes photos, serving as a visual archive to combat the erasure of history.
- **The Road:** The physical roads Iduma travels are often in disrepair, symbolizing the **broken state of the nation** and the difficulty of accessing the past. The checkpoints he passes remind the reader that the tension of the war has never fully gone away.
- **The Name "Golibe":** The name means "Rejoice." It symbolizes the **lost potential** of the young nation of Biafra and the young man himself. Instead of rejoicing, the family was left with mourning.
- **The Unmarked Grave:** A recurring symbol of **lack of closure**. Without a grave, the grieving process cannot be completed. The book becomes a textual grave—a place to finally lay the uncle to rest.

Why this book matters

I Am Still With You is significant because it breaks the "culture of silence" in Nigeria. It validates the pain of the Igbo people and asserts that the personal story is just as important as the official political history. It is a story about love, loss, and the lengths we go to for family.

I. Additional Themes

1. The Metaphysics of Presence (The Title's Meaning)

The title, *I Am Still With You*, is not just a comforting phrase; it is a metaphysical assertion. In Igbo cosmology, the line between the living and the dead is porous. Ancestors are present in daily life.

- **Theme:** The book argues that the dead do not leave us just because they die; they only leave if they are forgotten. By writing this book, Iduma is engaging in a spiritual ritual to keep his uncle "present" in the world of the living.
- **Duality:** The phrase cuts both ways—the dead are with us (haunting us), and we are with them (remembering them).

2. Vulnerable Masculinity

War stories in Nigeria (and globally) are often hyper-masculine, focusing on bravery, strategy, and stoicism. Iduma disrupts this.

- **Theme:** He presents a narrative of male vulnerability. He writes about men crying, men failing, men feeling lost, and men loving other men (fraternally).
- **Contrast:** He contrasts the "hard" silence of his father's generation with his own "soft" inquisitiveness. He shows that true strength is not in silence, but in the courage to ask painful questions.

3. The Ethics of Storytelling

Throughout the journey, Iduma wrestles with a meta-fictional dilemma: *Who owns a story?*

- **Theme:** He worries about whether he is exploiting the pain of strangers for his book. Is he a pilgrim or a tourist? When he interviews a survivor, is he giving them a voice, or is he reopening a wound? The book constantly questions its own right to exist.

II. Deeper Character Analysis

1. The "Unknown Soldier" (The Collective Character)

While Golibe is the specific focus, the book is populated by a chorus of nameless figures—the "Unknown Soldiers." Iduma realizes that Golibe is not unique; he is one of thousands. This realization shifts the book from a family biography to a **collective elegy**. Every time Iduma hits a dead end in his

search for Golibe, he finds a story about someone else's brother, making the "Unknown Soldier" a pervasive character in the text.

2. The Grandmother (The Waiter)

Though she appears less frequently than the father, Iduma's grandmother (Golibe's mother) is a crucial figure of **endurance**. She represents the women left behind—the ones who had to keep the family together while the men disappeared. Her grief is less silent than the father's; it is woven into her very existence and the atmosphere of the family home.

3. The Landscape (The Silent Witness)

The physical terrain of eastern Nigeria acts as a character. The forests where ambushes happened, the roads that were once escape routes, and the bunkers that still exist—the land remembers what the people try to forget. Iduma treats the geography as a witness that he must interrogate.

III. Additional Symbols

1. The Niger Bridge

The bridge crossing the River Niger is a massive symbol in Biafran history and the book.

- **Symbolism:** It represents the **threshold**. Crossing it meant entering the war zone (Biafra). For Iduma, crossing it physically represents entering the "land of the dead" or the land of memory. It is the boundary between the rest of Nigeria (which moved on) and the East (which remembers).

2. The Biafran Pound (Currency)

Iduma encounters the defunct currency of the breakaway republic.

- **Symbolism:** It represents **worthlessness and value** simultaneously. Economically, the money is trash (paper). But emotionally and historically, it is a priceless relic of a dream that failed. It symbolizes the persistence of an identity that officially "does not exist."

3. Fog and Mist

Atmospherically, Iduma often describes the weather, particularly mist or fog during his travels.

- **Symbolism:** This represents the **opacity of history**. Just as he cannot see clearly through the mist on the road, he cannot pierce the "fog of war" to get the clear, factual answers he craves. It reinforces the theme that some truths are permanently obscured.

4. The "Ofo"

In Igbo tradition, the *Ofo* is a staff that symbolizes truth, justice, and ancestral authority.

- **Symbolism:** Though not always explicitly wielded, the concept of the *Ofo* underpins Iduma's quest. He is seeking the "truth" necessary to restore balance to his family lineage. Without the truth of what happened to Golibe, the family's spiritual *Ofo* is incomplete.

Summary of the "Shadow" Narrative

If the "surface" narrative is a detective story about finding a missing uncle, the "shadow" narrative is about **healing a generational wound**. Iduma realizes he cannot "find" Golibe in the physical sense (a body), so he finds him in the metaphysical sense—by acknowledging that the grief itself is the connection. The book concludes not with a discovery of bone, but with a recovery of love.